Deaf Day

By Leslie Ayvazian

INTRODUCTION

In the United States, more than 40,000 profoundly deaf children struggle to compete in a hearing world. Deaf children, in many respects, are not all that different from hearing children. They can be fascinated by a passing butterfly . . . devastated by a sudden rainstorm . . . rejoice in digging into a pile of autumn leaves. However, in other respects, hearing-impaired children are definitely distinct from their peers. They have their own way of communicating…their own way of looking at the world . . . and their own way of interacting, both with each other and with the hearing world at large. Their first teachers are, of course, their parents and for this very reason they have a major impact on whether their child faces his/her hearing loss as a disability or as a challenge.

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[A deaf mother talking to a deaf child, who does not appear on stage. Spoken aloud in English and also in Sign Language]

MOTHER: Ok.

Ready?

Come on!

Sun's up, Day's here. Let's go!

Rise and shine.

That means: "Get up and...be happy!" Come on.

Don't ignore me.

Look at me! Yes!

We have to practice English.

Yes. Today is practice day.

Your teacher said.

So look at me. Look at me!

Put your hearing aids in. Yes!

Now! Good.

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Ok.

We're going to the playground.

No, not at Deaf School.

In the Park.

Yes, there will be hearing children there.

I don't know if there will be any deaf kids. You can speak to the hearing children.

Yes, you can.

Sure, you can.

Remember the new boy on our Street? Roger? Maybe we'll see new boy Roger and his Dog!

You can talk to them. Yes!

And to other kids too.

Yes, you can.

You stand in front of them.

Look directly in their faces.

If they look away, say:

[No Sign.] "Could you please repeat that?" *[No Sign.]* "Could you please repeat that?"

[With Sign.]

Yes, you can!

Say:

[No Sign.] "I can't hear you because I'm deaf." *[Continues aloud and with Sign.]*

Some will laugh.

Some won't laugh.

Talk to the ones who don't laugh. Come on, honey.

Yes.

Put your shoes on.

Put your shoes on!

I'll put them on you!

Then sit down and put them on! Sit down!

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Now tie your shoes.

Good.

Ok.

Get up. Get up! Get up! Look at me!

Don't turn your head away. Come on.

Ok.

I'll wait...

[She waits. She taps her foot.]

Hi.

Yes, I'll stay in the park with you, of course.

I'll sit on the closest bench.

You can talk to me whenever you want.

People may watch you.

And some may think: "WOW! Look at this kid!

He knows two languages! How cool!"

Well, some will think, "WOW!"

Some might be stupid.

We will ignore the stupid ones.

Do we feel sorry for the stupid ones?

Nah.

We think they're stupid.

But, some people will see how wonderful you are.

And those people will want to talk to you.

So, watch their faces.

Read their lips.

If they walk away without telling you where they are going, don't be mad.

Hearing people talk with their backs to each other.

At those times, wave to me.

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We will talk.

And then, we'll come home. Yes.

And you can be quiet for as long as you want to be quiet.

No voices. Quiet.

Quiet.

Ok.

You ready?

Hearing aids, turned on!

Eyes open!

Let's go!

No, we don't have to march.

We can walk slowly!

We can walk real slowly. And we'll look at each other. And we'll talk.

In Sign.

We'll talk.

I promise. *[Without Sign.]* Good. *[Without Sign.]*

[Lights shift. Lights come up. It is the same day: evening. She speaks aloud and with Sign.]

Hey.

It's almost time for bed! Yes, it is!

And you have sleepy eyes. Yes, yes, yes, you do. But first. . .

Look at me, honey. *[Hits floor for his attention.]*

[In just Sign.] Look at me! Good. *[Continues aloud and with Sign.]*

Let's practice English before we go to bed.

Practice Day is nearly finished. Watch my face.

Come on, watch.

Let's talk about the Park.

No. No Roger! No dog. No.

But the seesaw! Yes!

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That girl!

No, we don't know her name.

But you two were perfectly balanced!

You sat in the air at the same time.

That's very special.

But the slide. I know.

They pushed you down the slide.

They wanted you to go faster.

They said: "HEY! ...HEY!"

They didn't know that you couldn't hear them. So, they pushed.

They pushed hard. I know.

It surprised you.

And it hurt you. I know.

They pushed you because they were frustrated with you.

But I think you can understand.

Sure you can.

Think about your deaf friends at school

When you want their attention, sometimes you grab them. Sometimes you hit them. Sure you do. Because you want them to look at you.

And you get frustrated. Yes, you do!

So, next time, if the kids are waiting, you go fast! Ok!

Go fast down that slide.

You kick butt!

Yes!

Then no one will push you.

And no one will laugh.

You need to be fast and quick, quick, quick. Like a bunny.

Yes.

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A fast bunny who kicks butt!

That's you!

Yes!

Right! Jackie Chan!

Ok.

[Jumps up and does Jackie Chan stance.]

Jackie Chan!

Auhhhhhh!

[Does Tae Kwon-Do kick.]

We are Jackie Chan!

[Another move.]

But we have sleepy eyes!

Yes.

[Said in Korean, no Sign.] Cha-Ryut. Kyung-Net. [Bows to him.] Tae Kwon-Do.

[Back to Sign and English.] So get in bed, Jackie Chan! And maybe, tomorrow we'll go to the Planetarium. Or the Zoo?

Maybe the Park.

And you can get back in the saddle.

That means: When you ride a horse and fall off, you need to get back on the horse right away. So you don't feel scared.

Back in the saddle.

Back in the Park.

Back on the slide.

Ok?

Ok.

Now sleep, honey.

Sweet dreams.

[She waves.]

Sweet dreams.

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[She leaves "his room" and sits. She waits. Then she gets back up and goes to his room. She sees he is still awake, but sleepy. She waves again. She leaves and goes back to her chair. She waits. Then she goes again and checks on him. He's asleep. She returns to her chair and sits. She breathes a sigh of relief Beat. She notices he has walked into the room. She speaks aloud and in Sign]

What's up?

Tomorrow? Stay home? All day?

No voices?

Quiet?

I'm thinking.

[She gets up and sits on the floor]

Ok.

Tomorrow.

Quiet.

I promise.

Yes.

[In just Sign.] Quiet. Quiet. I promise. *[In Sign and aloud.]* Good night.

[In just Sign.] Good night.

[She sits watching her son. Lights fade.]

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Leslie Ayvazian
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AWARD HISTORY

2001 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
UT State Qualifier